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American myth is replete with romantic stories of tortured geniuses, artists with talent so magical that it seems instinctive, or the product of hallucinations, or a gift from some supernatural emissary. One such artist is legendary Mississippi blues man Robert Johnson, an African American musician who lived hard, died young, and left an enduring legacy of music and myth. Although he was virtually forgotten after his death in 1938, his rediscovered music inspired British and American rock stars in the 1960s, who saw in this hard-living, wandering musician a symbol of their own cultural alienation. When Columbia Records issued his *Complete Recordings* in 1990 (the first-ever CD box set), it went platinum in sales. Since then, Robert Johnson has become well known for the continuing influence of the twenty-nine songs he recorded. But he is probably even better known for the persistent legend that he sold his soul to the devil at a crossroads in exchange for his musical talent.

In the past twenty-five years, artists and scholars have produced myriad reflections on Johnson, his music, and the legend of his crossroads pact. These written responses have one fact in common: almost all of the writers are white. Among literary artists, Walter Mosley and Sherman Alexie are rare exceptions. Insofar as the audience for the blues today consists primarily of middle-aged white people (those of us who formed our musical tastes listening to Cream, Led Zeppelin, and the Rolling Stones, all of whom recorded Johnson's songs early in their careers), this attention from white scholars is somewhat predictable. But since these scholars come from all over the United States and, indeed, the world, with most born well after Robert Johnson died, cultural misunderstandings in interpreting his legacy seem unavoidable.

Several African American playwrights have undertaken to counter this racial imbalance, staging Robert Johnson's story within cultural contexts similar to his own hybrid one, and thereby functioning as Neo-Hoodoo dramatists, determined to empower black Americans. I use the term "Neo-Hoodoo" not in the Ishmael Reed sense from the 1960s, but as revised for the twenty-first century by the writer, bluesman, and griot Arthur Flowers. "Ishmael is good at cursing folk, he slashes and burns" writes Flowers, noting Reed's confrontational approach to social change (*Mojo* 87). In contrast, Flowers imagines a contemporary Neo-Hoodoo literature designed to nurture the African American community:

> Consciously griotic, African American literature is passionately concerned with cultural custodianship. As the voice of a culture that has since its inception felt itself under mortal siege, African American literature is fundamentally shamanistic and vitally concerned with communal health and empowerment. Its most revered figures have all been culturally engaged. Creating the visions without which the people shall perish and serving in its mythic heart its age-old griotic function of keeping the culture alive and viable. (79)

For Flowers, tribal guardianship—concern for the survival and spirit of African American people and their culture—is fundamental to Neo-Hoodoo art. Yet Flowers differs from Reed in another important way: while custodianship of African American culture is paramount, he strives to make his work more universally applicable (*Mojo* 117-18). He claims that Neo-Hoodoo artists see themselves as "heirs to two literary traditions, the Western written tradition and the African(/American) oral tradition" (*Mojo* 75). Their work is thus inherently intercultural; they function as caretakers of

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African American traditions while acknowledging, in Flowers's words, that "all folks are my tribe" and that Neo-Hoodoo writers can also give "strength to the human-race" (*Mojo* 117). Flowers's roster of contemporary Neo-Hoodoo writers includes August Wilson, Toni Morrison, Clarence Major, Gayl Jones, and Gloria Naylor. To his list I would add the names Adrienne Kennedy, Bill Harris, and Robert Earl Price, all playwrights who have written scripts about Robert Johnson, revising romanticized and stereotypical images of his life and work to create culturally empowering versions.

It should not be surprising that Robert Johnson, putative dabbler in the spirit world, is a focal point of Neo-Hoodoo work, but his potential as a Neo-Hoodoo figure has been largely neglected. In 1993, Julio Finn, one of the first African American writers to publish on Johnson (in *The Bluesman*), made this very claim most vociferously. Finn's work is passionately idiosyncratic, and he certainly does not speak for all African Americans. However, he offers some important cautions about cultural outsiders' attempts to understand Robert Johnson's legacy. One example is Finn's response to the well-regarded Johnson biographer Peter Guralnick. Guralnick compared Johnson to such artists as Keats and James Dean, who captured the popular imagination in part because they died young (61). Finn first describes these analogies as "a blatant 'whitening' of black culture," and then tartly queries, "What, in the name of the Devil, has Robert Johnson got to do with Keats, James Dean, *et al*? Surely the likes of Magic Sam, Jimi Hendrix, Minni Ripperton [*sic*] and Bob Marley are more apt comparisons" (210). Finn's hostility to much white criticism occasionally leads him into making oversimplified and fallacious black/white distinctions elsewhere in *The Bluesman*. Nonetheless, he makes a good case for trying to include more diverse perspectives on Robert Johnson.

Finn strongly identifies himself as African American. Focusing, like Reed and Flowers, on the cultural similarities among Africans, African Americans, and other circum-Atlantic black peoples, Finn reads the story of Johnson's deal with the devil in the context of Yoruba rituals, which include a ceremony of supplication to the god Legba, guardian of the crossroads, to seek artistic inspiration. Arthur Flowers concurs in this assessment, noting the similarities between legends pertaining to Robert Johnson and the importance of the crossroads in Yoruba theology as a site "where the mundane and the Sacred meet. This world and the spiritworld" (*Mojo* 74). Seen in this light, the story of Johnson's selling his soul to the devil at a crossroads, often discredited as marketing hype, may simply refer to an African spiritual retention, a ritual that Johnson and his contemporaries may have practiced, yet about which Western researchers knew little until recently.

Finn's insights are particularly relevant for examining the stage treatments of Robert Johnson by the three African American playwrights whom I see as "cultural custodians," working (consciously or not) in the Neo-Hoodoo tradition. When writers and artists recirculate Johnson's legend today, they generally do so to make some point about contemporary American culture. Sherman Alexie, for example, uses Robert Johnson in *Reservation Blues* as a parallel to today's disaffected Native American youth, suggesting that music and attention to indigenous spiritual traditions can help them overcome feelings of dispossession. Similarly, in *Crossroad Blues*, Ace Atkins uses deep familiarity with Johnson's music to create a superficial blues authenticity for his white, well-educated protagonist. But Adrienne Kennedy, in her unpublished film treatment *Robert Johnson* (1983), Bill Harris in his play *Trick the Devil* (published 1995), and Robert Earl Price in his play *Come on in My Kitchen* (premiered 2006) are all "culturally engaged" African American artists who redraw the portrait of Robert Johnson's pact with the devil, placing his legend within the multiple contexts of Western and African, white and black, literary and oral traditions. For Kennedy and Harris, the devil myth is an insult to Johnson's dedication and talent, a legend based on racist assumptions designed to discredit and/or appropriate Johnson's artistry. In contrast, for Price, Robert Johnson's pact with the devil *had* to be true, since the

only way African Americans can succeed in American culture is to sell parts of their souls. Taken together, these artists suggest that only by viewing Johnson through the prismatic lens of intercultural awareness can we understand his lingering impact and realize the cultural empowerment central to the Neo-Hoodoo project.

Adrienne Kennedy: "An Immense Poetry inside My Life"

Adrienne Kennedy has always been noted for the autobiographical impulse in her work. She has directly stated that "All the characters I write are a blend of people I know and myself" (qtd. in Barnett 164). While we see this mingling of fact and fiction, self and character, most clearly in her recent plays featuring the character Suzanne Alexander, a playwright and an obvious alter ego, its presence also informs her unpublished 1983 film treatment *Robert Johnson*. Kennedy's Robert Johnson is a tortured genius, his guitar mastery equally the product of his troubled life, his dedication to craft, and his innate talent. The devil exists in this world, but he is not the source of Johnson's gifts.

According to Kennedy, she was commissioned to write this screenplay by producer Judith James, then co-head of the Mark Taper Forum's Film and Television Department. Kennedy recalls that James had planned to create a series of films based on the lives of important African American artists, although only one of them seems to have been completed ("Screenplay"). Yet Kennedy's interest in Robert Johnson as an artistic figure parallel to herself makes perfect sense in any case, given the profound importance of music in her life. In her 1996 autobiography *People Who Led to My Plays*, she emphasizes her lifelong passion for music of all cultures, from the influence of early piano teachers to her reverence for classical masters, contemporary jazz artists, and practitioners of every musical form in between. From listening to string quartets, Kennedy the artist learned that "dark, impossible, unbearable moods could be transposed into work. A creative person could capture what he [*sic*] felt in andante, allegro and molta bella" (*People* 87); from Duke Ellington she discovered "that there was an immense poetry inside my life as an American Negro if I could find it" (*People* 106). The artist's use of her own personal experience, attention to art from all cultures, and reverence for the poetry of African American lives are all important themes in *Robert Johnson*.

Kennedy's script blends known facts about Johnson with fictional elements. Her knowledge of Johnson's biography is impressive, given that in 1983 the major research into his life had not yet been published. Greil Marcus's speculative essay on Johnson in *Mystery Train* had appeared in 1975 and Peter Guralnick's slim but seminal *Searching for Robert Johnson* was published in 1982, but the groundbreaking research of such scholars as Stephen C. LaVere, Gayle Dean Wardlow, Jas Obrecht, and Barry Lee Pearson would not appear until the 1990s. In terms of imaginative literature about Johnson, only T. C. Boyle's story "Stones in My Passway, Hellhound on My Trail" (1979) appeared before Kennedy wrote her script, and her screenplay indicates that she possessed biographical information about Johnson that Boyle lacked. But, as noted, in typical Kennedy fashion she blends fictional elements into Johnson's real story, even when the fiction differs from the facts as she clearly knows them.

Take the case of Johnson's mother. Kennedy is familiar with the details of Julia Dodd's life story, her troubles with the white men who stole her first husband's property, her several marriages, her affair with the sharecropper who fathered Robert, her abandoning Robert for a time. Kennedy includes all these details in her screenplay, probably to document the tribulations of Robert's life. But she changes Julia's name to Lavinia. She does likewise with Virginia Travis, Johnson's first wife who

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died young in childbirth, naming her Janice instead. As an anonymous, apparently unpublished press release filed with the typescript of *Robert Johnson* contends, "Adrienne Kennedy's ROBERT JOHNSON is intentionally fiction, even though it may actually coincide with some of the 'facts.' It intentionally concentrates on the more creative process" (Taper). Given that all Kennedy's characters are, to her, "a blend of people I know and myself," she is highlighting the methods that absorb all creative people, suggesting that creativity is a blend of imagination, innate talent, and unrelenting commitment to craft. This insistence on both talent and dedication as precursors to artistry applies equally well to Kennedy herself, to her character Robert, and, by implication, to all dedicated artists, even one whose reputation has been tarnished (in her implied view) by supernatural explanations of brilliance.

The script's descriptions of Johnson amply demonstrate Kennedy's vision of him as, first, a musical genius. From the moment we meet him, he walks through the world with music filling his head, " 'hearing' chords, music, like a Beethoven. He is possessed by chords, music, words" (4-5). Later, "Chords rush and plummet through his mind" (9), chords that we as audience members hear as well, although the other characters do not. Throughout the text Kennedy honors Robert's genius by comparing him to William Blake, Rembrandt (3), Beethoven, Marlon Brando, Miles Davis (4), Vincent Van Gogh, Mme. Curie (5), and Orpheus (32). Unlike Julio Finn, who resents comparing Robert Johnson to white celebrities who also died young, Kennedy sees no racial divisions among true artists, preferring to draw on the entire history of creative ancestors. As Philip Kolin has noted about Kennedy's eclectic musical tastes, "Musically speaking, everything blends harmoniously for Kennedy; there is no valorizing of white or black music or musicians" (Kolin 295). This is not to say that African American culture and history are not crucial in Kennedy's vision of Robert Johnson, because (as we shall see) they most definitely are. But apparently for her, artistic genius transcends cultural differences.

Kennedy's Robert Johnson thus began with extraordinary talent, but he developed it through persistent attention to his craft. We witness him working hard to improve his musical skills, from his childhood interest in learning to play instruments to his adult commitment to repeated practice. In one scene we see him riding in a boxcar "practicing and playing," and the notes tell us that "Robert doesn't escape the slight madness that comes with pre-occupation with music. . . . Robert is definitely possessed the way that a Stephen Crane or a Richard Wright would be" (17). Clearly this vision of a determined, slightly mad Robert Johnson is designed to counter the notion that his gifts came from the devil, and perhaps to suggest as well that Kennedy's own work is also the product of both industriousness and genuine inspiration.

But as Kennedy's autobiography *People Who Led to My Plays* reminds us, talent and craftsmanship are not the sole components of an artist's œuvre. Kennedy's very title suggests that other people, from immediate family members to famous artists to broader social movers, also influence artists at work, and indeed, her autobiography "maps a constellation of influences" (Belle's Reviews) of people who inspired her work. We see a similar "constellation" at work in her vision of Robert Johnson. Starting from an immediate family perspective, Robert's life included a great deal of private sorrow, from his childhood abandonment to his uncertain paternity to the loss of his young wife and child. While these incidents are based on real events in the historical Robert Johnson's life, Kennedy augments the suffering by introducing the fictional character of Robert's cousin Jesse and inventing fictional events around his life and death. In her script, young Robert and Jesse skip church to go play near a railroad track, where Jesse stumbles and dies by electrocution. This memory recurs at several points in the screenplay, suggesting that Robert is haunted by this loss and his guilt by association. To compound the grief even further, Robert's stepfather, already resentful of his wife's illegitimate son, blames Robert for Jesse's death and eventually evicts Robert from his home as a result. Interspersed through all these

moments of recollected trauma are images of Robert playing music, always described as "joyful." For Kennedy, art can be born of pain, but it also overcomes tragedy.

In the case of Robert Johnson, though, as for Kennedy, the broader social context—the time and place in which an artist lives—plays an equally important role in an artist's life and work. In *People Who Led to My Plays*, Kennedy lists Hitler and the Japanese who bombed Pearl Harbor as influences on her writing, intermingling discussion of them with her recollections of her grandparents, the Cleveland Indians, her fourth-grade teacher, and Jack Benny (26-29). Robert Johnson lived in Mississippi in the 1930s, a time and place in which African Americans faced unrestrained white oppression and violence, exaggerated by the privations of the Great Depression. In Kennedy's vision, Johnson's music emerged from these conditions as well as from his own genius and craftsmanship. Her attention to social tensions is apparent early and often in the script.

One of the first things we learn in the screenplay is that there have recently been two murders in Hazlehurst, the Mississippi town where Kennedy places Robert's family: one of an unknown black man and the other of a little black boy named Honeybunch. Near the end of the script, racial tensions are about to boil over in the community. Blacks live in terror of whoever murdered Honeybunch and the unknown man. We see repeated signs enforcing Jim Crow segregation, both in the train station and at a drinking fountain. Robert's young niece Charlene writes to him about seeing a chain gang pass by and hearing rumors of war. Kennedy's Robert Johnson is in tune with the world around him, aware of social conditions both at home and abroad. Unlike T. C. Boyle's Johnson, a naïf who "spent six weeks in Chicago and didn't know the World's Fair was going on. . . . He's never heard of Hitler. . ." (Boyle 147), Kennedy's Johnson has heard of Marcus Garvey and his back-to-Africa campaign (8), reads poetry by James Weldon Johnson (10), collects postcards from friends in London and New York (10), and receives highly encouraging mail from Langston Hughes, who hails Robert as a "true Negro genius" and "an Orpheus" (32). In short, Kennedy's Johnson is a man of and in the world, influenced (for good or ill) by the events, artists, and culture around him.

The appearance of a white stranger, a New York music producer named Paul Cook who travels to Mississippi in search of Robert, increases racial tensions in Hazlehurst. In a maneuver that at first seems odd, Kennedy begins the script with several scenes featuring Paul, his socialite sister Penny, and their New York art world, populated by a mixed-race crowd of artists, musicians, producers, and fans. This framework ends with Penny's suicide, but not before she has introduced her brother to the music of Robert Johnson, which she and her dear friend Langston Hughes have discovered together. It is Penny's death that propels Paul on his trip South, hoping to enlist Johnson to play at a New York concert.

This story is very loosely based on the real-life producer John Hammond's interest in Johnson. Hammond sought Johnson to play at his 1938 *From Spirituals to Swing* concert at Carnegie Hall, but discovered Johnson's whereabouts only shortly after the blues man's death. But the story of Penny and Paul is fiction, providing a provocative context for the internal story of Robert Johnson with which the screenplay is primarily concerned. It suggests, first, the overwhelming importance of white music producers in shaping the careers and determining the success of the black blues artists whom they sought to record and promote. While this world is completely alien to that inhabited by Johnson and his peers, it nonetheless circumscribes their possibilities. Yet this urban, Northern white framework world disappears once the story of Robert Johnson commences, only to reemerge near the end of the script when Paul appears "at the worst possible moment in several years for a New York White person to be entering Hazlehurst" (34). Scenes of his entry into town, marked by fear and hostility among the black residents, are interspersed with scenes involving a fictional character named Mary Lee. The historical Robert Johnson

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was apparently poisoned to death in a love triangle, and in these late scenes of the screenplay we see Mary Lee, a scorned former lover of Kennedy's Johnson, contemplating a jar of mysterious white powder. Taken together, these closing scenes suggest that Robert's musical future and his life are, unbeknownst to him, in the hands of others. For Kennedy, Johnson's musical accomplishments were the result of his talent and toil; his early death was the product of social forces and his own bad judgment. Neither resulted from a pact with Satan.

In revising the popular notion of Robert Johnson as a Faustian figure, Kennedy serves as a Neo-Hoodoo griot figure, "keeping the culture alive and viable." In one final parallel between Kennedy and her alter ego, she depicts Robert Johnson himself functioning as a cultural custodian. This aspect of Kennedy's Johnson is most apparent in his relationship with his young niece Charlene, a fictional character whose role is to humanize Robert and show his attachment to his family and his Mississippi roots. In one charming scene, he and Charlene sit on his mother's porch on a summer evening. There, he regales the child with a fable about the constellations, telling her that at one time "a burning light fell across the moon," turned into a lion, and terrorized the farmers until one brave man hurled the lion back into the sky, "and that's why there's a lion in the sky tonight" (8-9). This tale reveals Robert's love for and kindness to the child, but more important, it echoes both African beast fables and the tall tales collected by another Neo-Hoodoo artist, Zora Neale Hurston. Here Robert, like Kennedy herself, preserves and transmits the oral culture that has always sustained African Americans. In this way, Kennedy and Johnson, who is part fiction and part Kennedy, both emerge as Neo-Hoodoo practitioners, each one acting as what Flowers would call a "Tribal guardian. Tribal guide" (*Another* 161).

Bill Harris: The *Why* of the Myth

Like Kennedy's script, Bill Harris's *Robert Johnson: Trick the Devil* (published 1995) questions why Johnson's current fame rests as much on a Faustian legend as on his musical genius. The legend of selling one's soul for musical talent was widely circulated in African American communities in the South during Johnson's lifetime, but Harris objects to the way mainstream American culture has used the story to glamorize Johnson in recent years. He writes:

> Every society has its indelible and embedded myths, and they're necessary to that society. One of the things that I've wanted to do is raise discussion about these myths as they apply to African-Americans. . . . The whole idea of Robert Johnson having to sell his soul in order to be able to play the way he did . . . that's where I start . . . and then I examine the *why* of the myth. . . . Why does America need to believe that? (qtd. in Tysh)

In *Trick the Devil*, Harris exposes the cultural mythology around Robert Johnson and asks his audience to examine whose interests are served in creating and maintaining such fictions. He accomplishes this in several ways: first, by using realistic dramatic conventions to resituate Johnson in his original historical context; second, by dramatizing the very creation of the myth; and third, by depicting an African American cultural milieu that was considerably more sophisticated than has often been recognized by white artists and scholars. In Harris's view, Johnson and his contemporaries were vital in keeping a nurturing African American culture alive and flourishing.

Roland Barthes has argued that a myth is a semiotic sign divorced from history, and that by reinserting a sign into its original context one can, in Barthes's terms, "vanquish myth" (135). Harris takes that step, incorporating the limited biographical information known about Johnson into a detailed and realistic set and a specific social environment. Harris sets his play in Mississippi, in "Georgia Mayberry's

Colored Jook Joint" on the day in 1938 that Robert Johnson died. In *Trick the Devil*, Johnson is simply a working musician in search of a gig, avoiding the white man who has been following him, and seeking comfort and a free bed in the arms of Georgia Mayberry.

But is this restoration to history—this verisimilitude—really enough to vanquish myth? Robert Johnson will probably always be partly composed of the legends that have surrounded him, even if we take great pains to strip away those legends and replace them with his history as we understand it. As Ralph Ellison explains, a writer using an historical figure must be aware that he or she operates in a field "dense with prior assumptions" (74). Compounding this problem of meanings accrued over time is the very nature of history, which itself is not entirely factual, verifiable, or agreed-upon. History is, rather, the product of human interpreters with ideologies and agendas, conscious or otherwise. Given these problems with reconstructing history, Harris sought further strategies to emphasize the cultural construction of the Robert Johnson we know today.

A key element in this exposure of mythology as a construct is the character of Kimbrough, a pretentious Northern professor and the only white character, a more pompous parallel to the Paul character in Kennedy's text. Kimbrough enters the jook joint early in the play, searching for Robert Johnson; his language renders his outsider status immediately apparent. Unlike the lively vernacular spoken by Georgia Mayberry (the jook's proprietor) and Stokes (the blind piano player), Kimbrough speaks in blank verse, his dialogue replete with allusions to Shakespeare, his research specialty. Kimbrough freely admits that he is out of his element and that he is afraid; he sees the Mississippi Delta as "a world / of shadows and smoke where nothing [is] solid," a world unlike his own realm "of reason, / order and certainty. . ." (11). He is searching for Robert Johnson because the power of Johnson's recorded music has upset his preconceived assumptions about race and culture. Speaking directly to the audience, Kimbrough marvels that Johnson's songs remind him of the Bible and Shakespeare, that they resonate with themes of loss and atonement. He wonders: "How does he—this unschooled black Orpheus / produce songs as universal and complex / as the intellectual love of my life?" (24). Because Kimbrough accepts the stereotypes that Southern black people are primitive, superstitious, and violent, he is unnerved that Johnson's songs echo "universal" themes. Kimbrough apparently regards the Mississippi Delta as part of some "universe" other than his own.

Kimbrough has also heard the legend that Johnson sold his soul for his talent, but he doesn't know whether this or any other story about Johnson is true. Late in the play Robert Johnson himself tells the "true" story to Kimbrough—at least, as Harris imagines it. In this climactic monologue, Johnson explains that he did go to the crossroads at midnight, but the devil he met there was "just an ordinary white man in a suit and tie" (39). Playing and singing for this white devil, Johnson expresses not only his own life story but all of the misery in his racial memory: "the bondage, being bid for on the block, the lash, Jim Crow, the rope, the chain gang and the Klan. . . . And *that's* what got the Devil, because he couldn't call none of it a lie!" (40-41). Infuriated, the devil duels Johnson with his own guitar, and by copying the devil's skills, Johnson becomes a virtuoso. Harris's Robert Johnson beats the devil at his own game simply by telling—and playing—the truth. Harris thus refashions the legend of soul-selling into a lesson that can empower a culture "under mortal siege."

Just as Johnson feels hounded by his racial past, Kimbrough too is tortured by a secret: his family wealth originated from slaveholding ancestors. When Kimbrough confesses this, Robert Johnson encourages Kimbrough to "Go trick the Devil and tell the truth" (44). That truth, however, is too much for Kimbrough to face. Unwilling to give up his tainted fortune and unable to live with himself for keeping it, Kimbrough instead creates a legend about Robert Johnson that allows him to sidestep the truth. In the play's Epilogue we see him back home in Boston, lecturing

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to a class, creating a myth about Robert Johnson that fits neatly into the world-view that Kimbrough held before his Southern journey. Claiming that his research proves that Johnson was in league with the devil from the age of seventeen, Kimbrough describes Johnson in imagery more appropriate to Macbeth's witches, claiming that Johnson and Satan

> would consort during thunder, lightning
> and rain. And when they practiced their hurly
> burly the multiplying villainies
> of nature transmuted fair to foul
> and foul to fair. (45)

Kimbrough creates a myth about Robert Johnson that distances the truth-telling musician. He thereby preserves his "rational" world-view in the face of inexplicable musical genius and avoids acknowledging his own complicity with the hellhounds dogging Johnson and himself.

Harris thus uses Kimbrough to disclose the power relations that go into myth-making. In the context of Georgia Mayberry's jook joint, Kimbrough also embodies the racial divisions that mark American culture as a whole, and these divisions go well beyond the obvious differences of appearance and language. Harris ascribes a pragmatic view of the world to his rural black characters and a naïve romanticism to his more powerful white one. The realistic world-view of the black characters is best embodied by Lem, Georgia's estranged husband, who returns halfway through the play from working on a levee-building project, a realistic reference to the WPA and the Great Depression lurking in the background. Lem describes months of backbreaking labor under cruel white supervisors for little pay, with no time off. He enters the jook enraged at Johnson's presence in Georgia's bedroom and angry at the world. He warns her: "I ain't the same as I was before I went up there moving that dirt, so be careful, you don't know how much I can stand" (30). Like the terrorized black characters in Kennedy's Hazlehurst, Harris's Lem helps establish a link to the real-world social context in which the historical Robert Johnson and his peers struggled to survive.

Lem's life is most unlike the pastoral fantasies of the rural South that Kimbrough has harbored. Expecting to find an idyllic "world of soil tillers, idlers, [and] roaming song singers" (11), he discovers instead (in his words) "a powder keg ready to explode" (28). Stubbornly adhering to his preconceived assumptions, Kimbrough completely misreads the local culture. When Georgia and Stokes talk about Brer Rabbit and Brer Fox—stories about betrayal and wiliness relevant to the events at hand—Kimbrough dismisses them as "Nonsense tales. . . . Diversionary, but little more" (24). Unaware that the man he seeks will be killed that very day in the jook where he sits, Kimbrough recalls a jook dance he once witnessed as "Just darkie fun" (23). Repeatedly the black characters observe that white people "can't see nothing but what they want to see" (19), and Kimbrough repeatedly proves them right. Kimbrough's final retreat to the mythmaking lecture of the Epilogue is the ultimate abandonment of what he has learned, a betrayal of both Robert and himself. While imagining Johnson in league with Satan may restore his ability to function in his "rational" world—where poor black singers cannot be Orpheus—one wonders who has really sold his soul in this play.

This contrast between white and black cultures also allows Harris to present the creative hybridity of African American culture itself. This process starts in the opening scene, a rainy afternoon in the near-empty jook, where Georgia and Stokes trade stories that emphasize their double heritage as Americans and African Americans. Blind Stokes can see the future like a Mississippi Tiresias, a gift he has inherited from his grandmama, a practicing conjurer or "hoodoo woman." Georgia, who knows firsthand that Stokes's predictions come true, nonetheless sees herself

as someone who "went for Christian" rather than hoodoo (8). This double heritage of Western and African-influenced beliefs is reflected in the structure of Harris's play. Like most Western dramas, it moves through a linear, cause-and-effect plot, with characters' actions clearly motivated and plot complications leading to a climax and a dénouement. However, despite these roots in Western literary traditions—written forms—the play also celebrates the vibrancy of African American oral culture, including performances of many Robert Johnson songs as well as tall tales. Georgia and Stokes invoke numerous African American folk figures, from Brer Rabbit and Brer Fox to the Signifying Monkey; they imitate the black vaudevillians Butter Beans and Susie; they discuss cultural traditions like hoodoo healing "tricks" or the significance of names to African Americans. Through their exuberant dialogue they reveal the vitality and duality of African American culture, in which Christianity and hoodoo, written forms and oral traditions, all serve to inspirit a beleaguered people.

Writing in *The Souls of Black Folk* in 1903, W. E. B. Du Bois famously described this duality of outlook among African Americans as "double consciousness," or the ability of African Americans to see the world simultaneously from a majority viewpoint (as Americans) and from a marginalized one (as oppressed African Americans). Most commentators on Du Bois's notion of "double consciousness" focus on the difficulty of the condition, on the painful "twoness," the internal "war" that he describes. Yet Du Bois's definition includes some positive benefits as well. He describes double consciousness as a gift—as second sight, or the ability to see things others do not see (102). In the case of Harris's characters, this double consciousness enables them to function smoothly in two worlds: they know how to avoid revealing themselves to Kimbrough and they know how to survive the hardships of their own lives, often with grace and good humor. They easily recognize and manipulate multiple frames of reference; they can switch discursive codes as necessary, thereby navigating a world full of contradictions.

In this, the pragmatic African American characters contrast sharply with the bookish Kimbrough, the ivory tower romantic with no appreciation of multiple perspectives. Harris emphasizes the poverty of his monocular vision in the Epilogue, where Stokes, not Kimbrough, has the last word. Immediately after Kimbrough's lecture on Johnson's traffic with the devil—a chilling moment, since the audience knows that Kimbrough knows better—Stokes offers a final comment. Emphasizing his own "second sight" and offering interpretive options no Kimbrough could imagine, the blind musician says:

> Robert Johnson? He be back. He just going down to hell and ease some people's minds; maybe move some rocks around, even change the way the river run. Aw, he'll be back directly, don't you worry 'bout a thing. Just like he been here before he be back again. How I know? 'Cause it's happened before. And I seen it with my own eyes! (45)

With this comment, an amalgam of images from multiple cultures, the play ends. The picture of Robert Johnson that lingers is of a man with supernatural insights, prodigious talent, and an ability to rise again that links him to Christ, the phoenix, High John the Conqueror, or all three, depending on your cultural frame(s) of reference.

Bill Harris claims to have written this play to explore why America needs to believe the myths about Robert Johnson. *Trick the Devil* offers an uncompromising response. Harris discloses the very act of mythmaking as a result of willful misunderstandings and abuses of power. His inclusion of Kimbrough in the act of creating the myth, as well as his imagining the devil as a white man in a business suit, highlights the fact that white privilege often rests upon black exploitation. Yet as a Neo-Hoodoo writer, Harris also suggests that the besieged African American community will survive and flourish as long as it preserves its vibrant, polyphonous culture.

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Robert Earl Price: A Deal Is a Deal

In *Come on in My Kitchen* (2006), Robert Earl Price takes a somewhat different approach to cultural custodianship. Like Harris's play, Price's takes place in a jook joint, in this case, the one in Greenwood, Mississippi where Johnson was allegedly poisoned. However, Price's twenty-first-century sensibility gives his play another temporal framework, as it takes place simultaneously in 1938, the year Johnson died, and 2006, the year of the play's first production. This dual time frame allows Price to contrast a soulless, contemporary, media-saturated world with what he posits as a more authentic culture, one that emerged from traditions and community and that nurtures its members. His play functions primarily as a cautionary tale about the lengths to which African Americans must go in order to achieve power and prominence in contemporary American culture. For Price, selling one's soul is a necessary component of achieving this form of success.

The action of *Come on in My Kitchen* commences when "a planeload of today crash-lands in a field of yesterday" (2). On that plane are three prominent African Americans, known in the play simply as CR, CP, and CT, but whom we quickly come to recognize as thinly disguised avatars of Condoleezza Rice, Colin Powell, and Clarence Thomas. In the world of this play, prominent African Americans must return to the Greenwood jook joint each year on the anniversary of Johnson's death to renew their own deals with the devil. This overlapping of temporal and spatial realities is made visible in the set. Live theatrical action intermingles with video, and in the setting of a raw backwoods jook large projection screens blaze. The stage directions command that "video in some form should never completely disappear, utilizing front and rear projections, freeze frames, as well as live camera projections" (2). Robert Johnson may or may not have sold his soul at a lonely moonlit crossroads, but CR, CP, and CT have done so with the whole world watching.

The projection screens are used in several ways and for several purposes throughout the play. Among other things, they highlight the characters' moments of choice or duplicity, as when they try to renegotiate their deals with the devil. At these moments, their onstage actions are duplicated and enlarged by means of live camera projections, a sort of visual reverberation. So, for example, when CR is asked if she really thinks her boss, known only as HE, values her, a live camera projects her face onto a screen behind her, emphasizing her indignation as she claims, "Value? Look at me! I am a twofer; I am both a woman and a minority. I have demonstrated my ability to keep silent. . . . Even in the face of blatant disrespect I can keep my mouth shut and be a team player" (6). This sequence suggests several things about CR. First, we watch two of her as she gives this speech, suggesting that the character is internally divided by the choices she has made for success: double consciousness made visible. Second, her looming presence on the large screen could easily overshadow the actor on stage, intimating that CR has become a simulacrum, a copy without an original. Selling her soul has left her, like the other characters, devoid of self, unable to express viewpoints except through a carefully controlled media representation.

We see the deleterious effects of a mass-mediated existence in all three 2006 characters, but most evidently in CR, who must present carefully constructed media images of both her race and her gender to succeed in public spaces typically dominated by white men. CR asserts that she has made a good deal for herself as a "twofer," but the repressed parts of her nature nonetheless haunt her. In a private bedroom set off to the side of the jook, we see her switching clothes and selves, or, as the stage directions tell us, "swapping characters back and forth, a proper suit for a silken slip and transforming from her prim manner into a sultry seductive woman

of the world, [and back again]. . . . She is a divided soul trying to decide which self to repress" (9). It seems, though, that she has repressed them both. As she transforms herself over and over from a corporate bureaucrat to a seductive temptress, she tells us that "Neither is the woman that I set out to become" (9). Her rise to prominence as HE's trusted adviser has cost her both sexual fulfillment and the career she had wanted. She tells us that she had planned a career as a concert pianist, until she realized that "the power lies with the entertained and not the entertainers" (11). She had also planned a sexual life for herself. She remembers that it was a "sweet man" like Robert Johnson who first awakened her sexuality, "A man who would make you forget mother, church, and all of those 'keep your legs closed' lectures" (16). Ultimately, though, CR rejected both her sexual desires and her musical talent in order to serve at the right hand of white, male power, crafting a modern, female version of Johnson's deal with the devil.

But Price uses his large projection screens to do more than emphasize public/private divisions of character. He also includes characters that are not present in the Mississippi jook, characters who exist entirely in media representations. One of these characters is CR's boss, "HE." We see HE on screen only as the back of a head, as he phones CR, asking policy advice, annoyed at her absence from work. CR takes his calls at the crossroads, created on stage at key moments by intersecting lights. HE is described by CR as "the one who pays me for my mind" (12), but clearly HE owns her soul, too, or what's left of it. Telling her that he has located her by means of a "little teeny tracker chip implanted in your forehead—just joking" (24), HE hovers hugely over the action like Big Brother, or perhaps the Wizard of Oz (another simulacrum). The absent HE thus provides an uncomfortable reminder of Bush-era policies that compromise privacy and reflects the way media images now constitute political reality.

Two other contemporary characters also appear solely on the projection screens, and with each of them Price makes a distinct point about the power of the media. The first is a white man called Max, who is seen accepting an award on behalf of his deceased father, called only A. L., but clearly meant to suggest the folklorist Alan Lomax, one of the first field researchers to track down information about Johnson. With Max, Price seems to be jabbing at the Robert Johnson industry, the host of conferences, books, films, and papers that have buried the artist under a pile of myth. Like HE, Max is at the jook only as a virtual presence, but these two white characters both appear as enlarged copies of themselves, visible to the audience near the illuminated crossroads. This presentation suggests that both the publication industry and the government, powerful agents in their shared access to media and control of discourse, may be equally soulless enterprises, known to us and themselves only as media constructions. Like Kennedy's Paul and Harris's Kimbrough, these white characters circumscribe the possibilities available to African American lives, but unlike those others, they exist solely as distant yet looming media representations.

The final contemporary character to appear only on screen is called BC—Black Clergy. BC tells us that he started out as a preacher, but later decided to enter politics. "I went to the crossroads looking for a church," he says, until "I began to understand that running for office was like preaching, only with better privileges" (11). BC has learned that media presentation makes the man. However, in an echo of CR's insight into the entertainers and the entertained, BC realizes that the person being represented may not be the one with the power. In one of his sermons he wonders aloud, "Who gets to shape the image?" (16). BC tries to control his own image, continually redefining it, first as a preacher, then as a political speechmaker, and finally as a rap star. Price claims to have modeled this figure not on any particular person, but on "the founders of the black mega-churches who supported Bush" (qtd. in Holman) as a way to challenge the power dynamics of organized religion. BC is thus a chameleon, inhabiting whatever media representation will garner him

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the easiest gig with the best perks—even if he has to go to the crossroads and sell his soul to do it.

Taken together, these characters that exist only as disembodied, mediated images suggest two salient points. First, they illustrate the media control exercised by political power brokers and leaders of organized religions, who use the resulting visibility to dominate American culture and discourse, even in backwoods Mississippi. Second, they reveal that these prominent politicians, scholars, and clergy are remote figures, very distant from the daily reality of most Americans whom they nonetheless influence from afar.

One last character exists only on video in this play, and that is Robert Johnson. Referred to throughout the script as "Virtual RJ," an actor performing as Johnson appears periodically on screen to perform his songs, usually with lyrics that punctuate the action. He never interacts directly with the live characters on stage, and his performance is recorded, not projected live. Why would a play based on Robert Johnson present him in this indirect way? This question disturbed a few reviewers of the 2006 production. One of them, Wendell Brock, complained that "For a writer who gets his inspiration from music, Price certainly seems shy about using it. Johnson ([played by] Theodis Ealey) appears via video only—a virtual ghost on a portable screen." Brock's first point—that Price is heavily influenced by music—is readily apparent in his plays, which often center on such figures as Charlie Parker, Thelonious Monk, or Blind Tom Wiggins. Price spends so much time around musicians that he is often taken for one himself, to which he typically replies, "Yes—I play pencil" (qtd. in Holman). But Brock also seems to imply that the actor playing Johnson should have appeared live on stage, in the jook joint where he apparently drank that fatal dose of poison. To me, this represents a fundamental misreading of the play. Despite its title (borrowed from one of Johnson's most famous songs) and the Mississippi setting, *Come on in My Kitchen* is not a play about Robert Johnson. Rather, it is a play about the nature of compromise and the costs of fulfilling dreams, especially for African Americans (Rudy). But it is also about mass media's ability to shape culture and construct identity. In this context, using a virtual Robert Johnson rather than a live actor makes perfect sense. Robert Johnson as we know him today is not an historical person; he is a modern myth, the sum of thousands of representations, a floating signifier for consumers and media outlets.

These issues of knowledge, power, and representation saturate Robert Earl Price's vision in *Come on in My Kitchen*. From the intersecting structural elements to the multimedia technologies, *Come on in My Kitchen* presents race and politics as a crossroads where Faustian bargains are made every day and where media creates an empty, replacement identity for those who have sold their souls for recognition. But Price also presents an alternative model in the lively denizens of the jook who, like Georgia Mayberry and Stokes the piano player in *Trick the Devil*, preserve traditional elements of African American folk culture, a counterpoint to the vacuous media projections of the rich and famous.

Framing the activities of the contemporary characters are the jook's regulars: Tuner, who acts as master of ceremonies; Blues, "a Greek chorus of one" who comments on the action by singing classic blues as well as Robert Johnson songs; and the Blue Notes, "cynical commentators" who provide comic relief between scenes (1). Tuner begins the play, explaining the situation to the audience. He focuses on the Mississippi characters' daily experiences, as Lem did in Harris's play, emphasizing the harsh realities of Delta life: "Down here in the joints we abide by the rules of straight razor physics, and the habits of the natural sciences" (3). But he also offers the blues, an African American cultural production, as an antidote, as "sacred mantra, each note cooked down to a rich, rare roux." (3). He tells the legend of Robert Johnson's crossroads bargain, but deems it only "a myth to explain one man's miracle and another's failure" (4). "Remember," he instructs us, "ain't no devil

down here, just a mirrored room crisscrossed with propositions" (4). And in contrast to the Washingtonian characters, who all try to renegotiate their bargains, "Down here in the moonlit crossroad, a deal is a deal" (4). In this way he offers the Delta culture, where reality rushes at you head-on but where community and music offer solace, as a more authentic life experience than the mass-mediated one of CR, CP, and CT.

Since renegotiating their crossroads contracts is uppermost in the minds of the 2006 characters, they reject not only the comfort and affirmation of the blues ethos, they disparage the music itself. CT claims, "If I had my way this music would be outlawed, banned and eventually forgotten. . . . The Blues has no art to it and no place in colleges beside religion and law" (7). For CR, the blues is "a kind of folk music I think but I wouldn't know anything about common country music" (8); she prefers Mozart and Chopin, seeing the blues as a product of victimhood rather than as a source of uplift. CP, the most self-aware of the contemporary characters and blessed with memories of his West Indian grandmother, does see some power in the music, calling it "a soulful potion created to vaccinate hearts against misery and death and destruction" (11). However, in pursuing his military career he has abandoned the pleasure of the music, just as CR abandoned her sexual desires and musical aspirations to further her ambition. The three all try various renegotiating ploys, claiming that when they made their deals their fingers were crossed or that they had called "time out," but none of their strategies works in a world where "a deal is a deal." Price thus posits a culture where people keep their word, where they meet each other face to face, where they sing and dance and use humor to survive in a hostile world, just as Georgia Mayberry and Stokes did. Price does not romanticize this folk culture or the hardships the characters face daily, but he does show another way to live that seems more genuine, more human, than the mass-media projections that the others rely on to define them.

Conclusion: Crossroads Theology

For Arthur Flowers, Julio Finn, and others, blues musicians are always already "cultural custodians" for African American ways of being and knowing; historian Clyde Woods has called them philosophers in a working-class, unwalled university in the Delta. For Flowers, this blues ethos is tantamount to a religion, with the blues men and women serving as priests and priestesses. He writes:

> Officially repressed, Crossroads theology survived in Southern mythology and folk knowledge and was recorded by the blues. A griotic code serving an illiterate people in danger of losing their souls and championing cultural imperatives pertinent to our survival under actively hostile conditions. (*Mojo* 74)

All three of the playwrights discussed herein have attempted to show blues figures as bearers of truth, passing on cultural wisdom to people in need. We see this in Kennedy's Robert Johnson, who passes on creation stories; in Harris's Robert Johnson, who vanquishes the devil by telling the truth; and in Price's jook characters, who use steadfastness, humor, and the "sacred mantra" of the blues to survive. In this context Robert Johnson looms large, both as an historical figure with exquisite mastery of the guitar and as a contemporary icon with a resonant legend.

Just as the characters serve as cultural custodians, so too do the three playwrights themselves. These plays depict a Robert Johnson quite different from that envisioned by many white writers. They emphasize the hybridity of American culture while striving to offer models of endurance and joy specifically for African American

readers and spectators. These three dramatic texts may not be what Ishmael Reed envisioned when he first defined Neo-Hoodoo literature, but the playwrights continue his mission of empowering black people in a contemporary way. Collectively, they are "[f]orging a [dramatic] instrument worthy of 21st century nuance, an instrument of literary, political, and spiritual redemption" (*Mojo* 76).

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